particular gene at the expense of others. The forms that survive are those that are responsible for the bodily types and behaviors (phenotypic traits) that successfully promote their own propagation. Supporters of the theory argue that because heritable information is passed through the generations by the genetic material of DNA, both natural selection and evolution are best considered from the perspective of genes.

Dawkins was strongly influenced by the work of William Donald Hamilton on the nature of altruism and closely examined the biology of selfishness and altruism in *The Selfish Gene*. He argued that organisms were simply vehicles that supported their genes, or “replicators.” Genes that help an organism survive and reproduce tend also to improve those genes’ own chances of being replicated.

Successful genes often provide a benefit to the host organism. For example, a gene that protects an animal or plant against disease thereby helps that particular gene to spread. However, the interests of the replicator and the vehicle may sometimes seem to be in conflict. Genes drive the male black widow spider to mate despite the risk of being eaten by her. However, the male’s sacrifice nourishes the female and improves the prospect of his genes being passed on.